

Nathan Sanchez
Network Delaware

Delaware K-12 Civic Education: Policy Brief

Executive Summary

Delaware's K-12 civic education system teaches students about democracy, but does not reliably prepare them to practice it. The 2018 Civics Standard, the operative standards as of the 2024-25 academic year, contain no statutory mandate, no dedicated funding appropriations, no universal action civics requirement, and no accountability mechanism tied to LEA implementation. The result is a system with significant internal variation: some Delaware students experience high-quality, hands-on civic learning; however, many more, disproportionately those in under-resourced districts serving immigrant, Black, and Brown, and multilingual families, do not.

This brief presents five policy recommendations drawn from the Civic Education & Policy Research framework and grounded in a comparative analysis of five state models, a Delaware-specific landscape review, and the best available evidence on youth civic engagement outcomes. The recommendations are sequenced by implementation logic: each depends on or strengthens the others. The five recommendations are:

- Revise the Delaware Participation Anchor Standards to adapt civic participation
- Enact a statutory semester-long civics mandate with embedded equity requirements;
- Establish a dedicated Civic Education Grant Program prioritizing under-resourced LEAs
- Create a Community Accountability Structure with real authority over implementation review &
- Codify strategic Nonviolence and Leadership Development as a required curriculum component.

The Problem: The system teaches about democracy without preparing students to practice it.

The civic knowledge gap in Delaware, and nationally, is real but secondary. Fewer than one in four eighth graders nationally demonstrated proficiency on the most recent National Assessment of Educational Progress Civics Assessments (Thomas B. Fordham Institute, 2021). Delaware's DeSSA Social Studies assessments in grades 4, 7, and 11 track civic knowledge against state standards, but those standards are organized around understanding governmental process rather than practicing civic agency. The more consequential gap is participatory: students who name the three of government cannot run a meeting, build a coalition, or negotiate with a school board. CIRCLE's 2025 analysis of youth civic engagement data confirms that the primary barrier to youth participation is not motivation; it is access, safety, and structured invitation. Among the youth surveyed, significantly more indicated they would engage in civic action if given a structured, supported opportunity than had actually done so. The civic engagement gap is a

supply-side failure. Delaware's standards, as currently written, do not create the proper conditions with hands-on practice, community partnerships, and power-building skills that would close said gap.

Three structural features of Delaware's current system produce this outcome. First, the Participation anchor standard: the only anchor that asks students to do something civic rather than know something civic, is highlighted at the high school level only at grade 9. Grades 10, 11, and 12 have no highlighted Participation anchor. The Citizenship anchor is required only at grade 9 and asks students to "understand" individual civic responsibility without requiring demonstration at any point before graduation. Second, there is no universal action civics project requirement at any grade level; whether students complete hands-on civic work depends entirely on individual teacher discretion, which produces wide implementation variance and systematically underserves students in under-resourced schools. Third, Delaware provides approximately \$1,100 per multilingual learner in opportunity funding, compared with \$6,000 to \$9,000 in neighboring New Jersey and Maryland, a funding gap that directly constrains civic education access for Delaware's fastest-growing student population (WHYY, 2025).

As for the six priority communities for which Network Delaware serves, immigrant and mixed-status families, Black and Brown youth, Hispanic and Latino communities, disabled students, LGBTQIA+ youth, and multilingual families, it is more than a structural problem. A civic education system that teaches students to navigate existing governmental structures without equipping them to analyze, challenge, or reshape those structures is not complete. For students whose lived experience already places them in tension with government structures, it is actively disempowering.

Evidence Findings

Finding 1: Statutory mandates are necessary but not sufficient.

Illinois House Bill 4025 (2015) is the most comprehensive statutory civics mandate in the five-state comparison field, requiring a semester-long course with four evidence-based pedagogical practices. CIRCLE's multi-year evaluation found that implementation quality was significantly higher in schools with peer mentor support and significantly lower in under-resourced schools serving predominantly Black and Brown students, even with the mandate in place. The statute created a floor, not an equitable starting point. Delaware's reform must pair any statutory mandate with funded infrastructure, equity-disaggregated LEA reporting requirements, and community partnership connections in the same legislative vehicle.

Finding 2: Dedicated, stable funding tied to equity requirements is the mechanism that translates mandates into outcomes.

Massachusetts's Civics Project Trust Fund, established in 2018 at \$1.5 million annually and later fluctuating between \$1.5 and \$2 million, has distributed more than \$2.8 million to economically disadvantaged districts since its creation. Demand has significantly exceeded supply: since 2020, districts requested nearly \$6 million from the Trust Fund but received less than half that amount. CIRCLE's Massachusetts evaluation found that teachers who received civics professional development at least once annually reported significantly higher awareness and implementation of the 2018 framework requirements. The lesson for Delaware is direct: a grant program must be sized to meet documented district need, must require multilingual integration and community partnership as eligibility conditions, and must fund professional development as core infrastructure, not optional enrichment.

Finding 3: Action civics with direct decision-maker engagement produces the strongest and most equitably distributed civic outcomes.

Research on Generation Citizen's action civics model, using structural equation modeling with 903 urban middle and high school students, found that the relationship between democratic practice exposure and civic self-efficacy was significantly stronger for Black and Latino youth than for white youth. The mechanism is direct decision-maker contact: safety-themed projects with decision-maker engagement produced the most robust gains in future civic commitment (Cohen et al., PMC, 2017). The I-ACTED randomized controlled trial (BMC Public Health, October 2025) confirms that action civics produces positive well-being outcomes through civic connection and empowerment. These effects are not uniformly distributed; access to high-quality civic education remains structurally unequal, with under-resourced schools systematically underserved. Delaware's policy must specify that action civics projects require direct decision-maker engagement on student-selected issues, not merely research and presentation within the classroom.

Finding 4: Community power infrastructure is the mechanism by which civic education becomes credible and accessible for priority communities.

CIRCLE's Growing Voters framework and 2025 post-election data both establish that young people's civic trust clusters around personal networks and local institutions, family, neighbors, community organizations, rather than state-level political institutions. Youth who have political homes, defined as organizations and spaces that provide belonging, voice development, and opportunities for learning and action, are dramatically more engaged across every form of civic activity. Among 2024 youth voters, 27 percent reported being part of a movement or organized group, compared to 13 percent of non-voters. Delaware's civic education framework must treat community infrastructure, not classroom instruction alone, as the primary intervention point.

Finding 5: No comparison state has codified strategic nonviolence and leadership development in statute.

For Black and Brown youth navigating documented school discipline disparities, immigrant youth facing enforcement risk, and LGBTQIA+ students in hostile school environments, strategic nonviolence is not an optional enrichment component; it is the difference between civic participation and civic exile. No comparison state has integrated this component into statute. Delaware has a genuine opportunity to lead, and the From Civic Learning to Civic Power framework's differentiating argument rests substantially on this front.

Policy Recommendation

Recommendation 1: Revise the Delaware Participation Anchor Standards

DDOE, in partnership with the Delaware Civics Education Coalition and Network Delaware, should revise the Participation anchor standards to require students to analyze power, identify structural inequities, engage in organized advocacy, and practice collective civic action across all grade bands, not only in grade 9. The revision process must include formal representation from each priority community. This is achievable within the current standards review cycle and does not require new legislation. It is the prerequisite for all subsequent recommendations: a statutory mandate built on passive standards produces passive outcomes.

Recommendation 2: Enact a Statutory Semester-Long Civics Mandate with Embedded Equity Requirements

The Delaware General Assembly should pursue legislation modeled on Illinois HB 4025, establishing a mandatory semester-long civics course at the middle and high school levels. The legislative vehicle must simultaneously establish: a funded peer mentor and professional development system; equity disaggregation requirements for LEA implementation reporting; explicit pedagogical requirements for action civics, discussion of current and controversial issues, service learning, and simulations of democratic processes; and provisions requiring that all action civics projects involve direct student engagement with a decision-maker on a student-selected issue, guided by a teacher trained in power analysis facilitation, and connected to a community organization partnership. The Illinois implementation failure, mandate without equitable infrastructure, is the primary design risk Delaware must engineer against.

Governor Matt Meyer's March 2026 Civic Learning Week proclamation and the Delaware Civics Education Coalition's active organizing capacity represent the policy window for this legislation. That window should be treated as an opening for LEA-level and legislative advocacy, not only as a celebratory moment.

Recommendation 3: Establish a Dedicated Civic Education Grant Program

Delaware should establish a dedicated Civic Education Grant Program, administered through DDOE in partnership with the Delaware Civics Education Coalition, with the following mandatory design features. Grant eligibility must require: provision of all civic learning

materials in English and Spanish at a minimum, with a language access plan for additional languages represented in the participating population; partnership with at least one community-based organization serving the multilingual families or priority communities in the grantee's school community; and a sustainability plan demonstrating how civic education programming will continue beyond the grant period. Funding priority must be given to LEAs serving higher proportions of low-income students, multilingual learners, and students from the six priority communities identified in the From Civic Learning to Civic Power framework.

The Massachusetts model, \$1.5 to \$2 million annually, distributed to economically disadvantaged districts, with documented demand nearly doubling available supply, provides the design template. Delaware should size its grant program to meet documented district needs rather than setting an arbitrary floor. The multilingual learner funding gap, \$1,100 per learner in Delaware versus \$6,000 to \$9,000 in neighboring states, makes the multilingual eligibility requirement not aspirational but corrective.

Recommendation 4: Establish a Community Accountability Structure with Real Authority

Delaware should establish a formal Community Accountability Structure, modeled on Puerto Rico's Consolidated State Plan Goal 9, with formal representation from each priority community and explicit authority to: review LEA implementation data for the civic education mandate; issue formal findings to the state legislature on an annual cycle; and recommend corrective action where implementation is inequitable or insufficient. This structure must be designed in partnership with community-based organizations holding existing trust relationships with Delaware's priority communities, including La Esperanza, the Latin American Community Center, the Delaware Hispanic Commission, Equality Delaware, and disability advocacy organizations, rather than assigned top-down by DDOE. The distinction between a community advisory body and a community accountability structure is the difference between symbolic engagement and real power. The former is consulted and ignored; the latter has standing. This recommendation directly advances the framework's non-negotiable that families and students receive real power, not symbolic engagement.

Recommendation 5: Codify Strategic Nonviolence and Leadership Development as a Required Curriculum Component

Delaware's civic education statute should explicitly include strategic nonviolence and leadership development as a required curriculum component, the first state in the nation to do so. The curriculum must be developed through a community co-design process led by Network Delaware in partnership with community organizations holding trust relationships with immigrant youth, Black and Brown youth, disabled students, and LGBTQIA+ students in Delaware. The Rhode Island civic coalition model provides the process template; the Illinois peer mentor system provides the professional development delivery mechanism; the Kingian Nonviolence curriculum provides the substantive framework.

The curriculum must address three integrated components: power literacy (the ability to analyze how power operates in institutions and identify leverage points); conflict navigation (strategic de-escalation and principled engagement with institutional resistance); and leadership development as collective, transferable capacity, civic multipliers who carry knowledge forward into families and communities. The curriculum should be piloted in at least two school-community partnership sites in the first implementation year, with evaluation built in from the outset.

Conclusion

The argument for comprehensive civic education reform in Delaware is not ideological. It is empirical. The research base is consistent: students who experience structured action civics, connected to real community decisions, guided by teachers trained in power-conscious facilitation, and supported by community organizations with existing trust relationships, develop stronger civic identity, greater civic efficacy, and higher rates of long-term civic participation, with the strongest effects among students from historically marginalized communities. Delaware has the policy infrastructure, the institutional partners, and the political moment to build this system. What it lacks is the statutory, financial, and accountability architecture to make equitable implementation certain rather than exceptional.

These five recommendations provide that architecture. They are not a menu from which partial adoption is adequate; they form an integrated system in which each component reinforces the others. The From Civic Learning to Civic Power framework exists to build that system. This brief is the evidence base and implementation roadmap for moving it from proposal to policy.

Works Cited

Academy for Social Civics. "Delaware." Academy 4 Social Civics, 13 Oct. 2022, new.academy4sc.org/2022/10/13/delaware/.

Center for Information and Research on Civic Learning and Engagement (CIRCLE). "Equitable K-12 Civic Learning." Tufts University, 2024, circle.tufts.edu/our-research/equitable-k12-civic-learning.

Center for Information and Research on Civic Learning and Engagement (CIRCLE). "Growing Voters Year-Round: Program Examples to Build Youth Engagement." Tufts University, 7 Sept. 2023, circle.tufts.edu/latest-research/growing-voters-year-round-program-examples-build-youth-engagement.

Center for Information and Research on Civic Learning and Engagement (CIRCLE). "The State of Civic Education in Massachusetts." Tufts University, circle.tufts.edu/latest-research/state-civic-education-massachusetts. Accessed 20 Apr. 2026.

Center for Information and Research on Civic Learning and Engagement (CIRCLE). "Youth Are Taking Civic Action, But Need Opportunities and Support to Overcome Socioeconomic Barriers." Tufts University, 30 Sept. 2025, circle.tufts.edu/latest-research/youth-are-taking-civic-action-need-opportunities-and-support-overcome-socioeconomic.

Cohen, Alison K., et al. "Action Civics for Promoting Civic Development: Main Effects of Program Participation and Differences by Project Characteristics." PubMed Central, 2017, [pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC5654523/](https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC5654523/).

Cohen, Alison K., et al. "The I-ACTED Study." BMC Public Health, vol. 25, 16 Oct. 2025, article 3513, doi.org/10.1186/s12889-025-24838-y.

Cyril, Khadijah Nelly. "The Kingian Nonviolence Conflict Reconciliation Training Program." Open Access Dissertations, University of Rhode Island, 2020, digitalcommons.uri.edu/oa_diss/1174/.

Delaware Center for Civic Education. University of Delaware Biden School, udel.edu/academics/colleges/biden-school/research-public-service/ipa/public-service/dcce/. Accessed 20 Apr. 2026.

League of Women Voters of Delaware. Delaware Civics Education Proclamation by Governor Meyer. League of Women Voters of Delaware, 14 Mar. 2026, my.lwv.org/delaware/article/delaware-civics-education-proclamation-governor-meyer.

Martínez-García, Marta, et al. "Interventions to Promote Civic Engagement Among Youth and Its Outcomes on Mental Health: A Scoping Review." Children, vol. 12, no. 6, 22 May 2025, doi.org/10.3390/children12060665.

Massachusetts Council for the Social Studies. "Increase Investment in Civic Education, Don't Decrease It." Oct. 2023, masscouncil.org/social-studies-in-massachusetts/.

Thomas B. Fordham Institute. "The State of State Standards for Civics and U.S. History in 2021." Fordham Institute, 23 June 2021, fordhaminstitute.org/sites/default/files/publication/pdfs/20210623-state-state-standards-civics-and-us-history-20210.pdf.

WHYY News. "Delaware Falls Short on Funding for Multilingual Learners." WHYY, 2025, whyy.org. Accessed 20 Apr. 2026.

Wray-Lake, Laura, et al. "Profiles of Civic Assets Among Youth of Color: Relations with Civic Action." *Journal of Youth and Adolescence*, ScienceDirect, Nov. 2022, [sciencedirect.com/science/article/abs/pii/S0193397322000880](https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/abs/pii/S0193397322000880).